



Tutor/Mentor Institute, LLC
Merchandise Mart PO Box 3303
Chicago, IL 60654

September 19, 2011

Institute of Education Sciences
555 New Jersey Avenue, NW
Washington, DC 20208

To Whom It May Concern:

Tutor/Mentor Institute, LLC is pleased to provide a letter of support on behalf of Dr. Roussos and his team at the Alliance for Community Research and Development (ACRD). I have known Dr. Roussos for more than 12 years as he has participated in tutor/mentor conferences I have organized in Chicago and collaborated with me in developing an on-line documentation system intended to capture actions that over time would lead to more volunteer-based tutor/mentor programs serving low-income K-12 youth in Chicago and other cities.

I understand that ACRD is proposing to develop an in-home tutoring program using dual language instruction to improve reading among English Learner (EL) students in second and third grades. Improving academic achievement in reading among our younger EL students is one of the "birth-to-work" strategies outlined by the Tutor/Mentor Institute, LLC and our region. Dual language instruction is one effective approach to closing the EL achievement gap. The development of a home-based tutoring program with dual language instruction may have similar positive effects and complement classroom instruction. I am very pleased to see ACRD working with local schools to co-develop such a promising innovation.

Tutor/Mentor Institute, LLC is located in Chicago, Illinois. Our roots go back to 1965 when employee volunteers from the Montgomery Ward Corporation began a tutoring program for elementary age children in the Cabrini-Green area of Chicago. I became leader of that program in 1975 and have continuously led a tutor/mentor program in Chicago until this fall. In 1976 I began to gather leaders of various programs together to share ideas and in 1993 I formalized this into the Tutor/Mentor Connection, which began building a master database of tutor/mentor programs serving Chicago and a library of information and ideas that leaders of each program could draw from to improve their own programs. We began sharing this information via conferences in 1994 and on the Internet in 1998. Now the ideas we share come from all over the world. In July 2011 I created the Tutor/Mentor Institute, LLC to continue this mission in Chicago while sharing our ideas more consistently with similar organizations in other parts of the country.

My expertise focuses on the "systems" and "knowledge" that are required to build structured programs that connect volunteers and youth to each other and keep them connected as youth grow from first grade through high school and on to jobs. We have worked with youth in high poverty neighborhoods and volunteers from different backgrounds and experiences and coach organizations in the processes and learning they might adopt to build and sustain their own programs.

I host an extensive research library on the Tutor/Mentor Institute web site showing the challenges of youth living in poverty and the importance of early age interventions intended to support reading and fundamental learning skills. If this project is funded, Tutor/Mentor Institute, LLC and Dan Bassill would be serve as advisors to its development and help the organization build on-going communications strategies needed to recruit families of EL students who may benefit from participation in dual language tutoring along with volunteers and donors who will be needed to sustain such a strategy over a period beyond the initial 3-year grant.

Dual language tutoring at the home of EL students may be an important addition to school efforts to close the EL achievement gap. We are excited about the possibilities and opportunities presented by this proposal and look forward to participating in this collaborative project.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads "Daniel F. Bassill". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Daniel" being more prominent than the last name "Bassill".

Daniel F. Bassill
President
Tutor/Mentor Institute, LLC
Tutor/Mentor Connection
Merchandise Mart PO Box 3303
Chicago, IL 60654

Grant Proposal for the Institute for Education Sciences
Stergios Roussos, PhD, MPH
Alliance for Community Research and Development
sroussos@acrd.us, 209-489-9913

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Funding Agency: Institute for Education Sciences

Partners:

Livingston Union School District, Merced County
California State University, Stanislaus, Department of Teacher Education
Tutor/Mentor Connection

Tutoring English Learners: The Development of a Dual Language Approach

Abstract

Schools nationwide are challenged to close the achievement gap for the large and growing number of English Learners (EL) students. Despite various strategies and tools, few have improved at a large enough level and not fast enough to help EL students. Dual Language (DL) instruction is one method that has demonstrated consistent improvements for EL students. Substantial research has shown that allowing EL students to use and learn their native or home language while learning English leads to faster improvement for both languages.

A development project is proposed to build on the lessons and successes of DL instruction through in-home tutoring for EL students and at least one parent or caregiver with limited English proficiency (LEP). In-home tutoring (as with the Family Literacy Program) has shown improvement for EL students and has found that incidental effects on parents and siblings who see the tutor as a model for learning. The in-home DL tutoring would be lead by schools to help EL students with at least one-grade level deficiency in reading. The program would assess and intervene with the EL student and LEP one parent/caregiver. Using DL methods, the curriculum implemented by the tutor would include both English and the target language for the student and the parent.

The project will be developed and tested for feasibility during a 3-year period. The project will focus on second and third grade students with an emphasis on reading ability. This is important because this time period is critical for students in their subsequent education that demands ever increasing levels of reading proficiency. The project will include the development of the tutoring curriculum, connections of the tutoring curriculum with classroom curricula and school goals, development and training of the DL tutors, and development and protocols for evaluation of all aspects of the project.

A team of school teachers, parents and administrators will collaborate with academic researchers throughout all phases of the development project. The end goal will be the creation of a systematic in-home DL tutoring program than can be implemented by grade schools to address reading disparities. The academic-community team will develop a plan for more rigorous research of the program's effects in a manner that can be easily and quickly disseminated to more schools, and eventually to other grade levels.